The Great Indian Migration Wave has, for the most part, been voluntary in nature. It represents an adventure, the ability to break out of the family's gaze and yet be able to support it, to enjoy the city lights and the company of friends and relatives, and finally to return home with the satisfaction of a life well spent, at least in the eyes of the others. For many though, this would not be the case as life would have cruel twists in store. The nemesis could be a worldwide recession leading to unemployment. It could be the landlord threatening to evict on account of delayed rent payments, or it could be a simple piece of paper with the word 'indenture' marked on it, a pre-passport visa to a new world of hope and, often, despair.

Organized emigration in India was initially associated with indentured migration that began in the 1830s. The system entailed fixed-term contracts of intensive labour, usually for three or five years, with no option to change the employer or terms of employment. The labourer was free to leave after the contract period ended. It came up in the 17th and 18th centuries to recruit poor Europeans for work in North America and played a major role in the 19th century colonial plantation economy after the formal abolition of slavery in some parts of the world. Charles Darwin was in Mauritius, a sugar plantation colony that used slaves, at this momentous time in 1836. He observed how little people cared about the abolition of slavery 'feeling confident in a resource in the countless population of India'.[62] When he did get to see Indians for the first time on the island, he keenly jotted down his observations, as he had done only a few months earlier on the finches in the Galapagos Islands that would eventually lead him to theorize on the evolution of species:[63]

> Before seeing these people I had no idea that the inhabitants of India were such noble looking men; their skin is extremely dark, and many of the older men had large moustachios and beards of a snow white colour; this together with the fire of their expressions, gave to them an aspect quite imposing.

Between 1831 and 1920, 2 million people were transported across continents through indenture contracts: one-third towards the Caribbean, one fourth towards Mauritius, a tenth towards South Africa and the rest